COLOSSIANS · STUDY 01 OF 12

Colossians 1:1–8

Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 1:1–8 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

1:1 *Paul, an apostle of Jesus Christ by the will of God, and Timothy our brother,*

2 *To the saints and faithful brethren in Christ who are at Colossae: Grace to you and peace from God our Father.*

3 *We give thanks to God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, praying always for you,*

4 *since we heard of your faith in Christ Jesus and the love which you have for all the saints;*

5 *because of the hope laid up for you in heaven, of which you previously heard in the word of truth, the gospel*

6 *which has come to you, just as in all the world also it is constantly bearing fruit and increasing, even as it has been doing in you also since the day you heard of it and understood the grace of God in truth;*

7 *just as you learned it from Epaphras, our beloved fellow bond-servant, who is a faithful servant of Christ on our behalf,*

8 *and he also informed us of your love in the Spirit.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

A Letter from a Prison to a Church He Never Saw

> *“because of the hope laid up for you in heaven, of which you previously heard in the word of truth, the gospel”*
>
> *— Colossians 1:5 (NASB95)*

Paul wrote these words in chains. He had never walked the streets of Colossae or looked into the faces of the believers there, yet he opens his letter with thanksgiving, not complaint. News had come through Epaphras, and the news was good: these believers were trusting Christ, loving one another, and resting in a hope that no prison, false teacher, or passing trouble could reach.

Notice the order Paul gives. Faith looks up to Christ and rests on what He has already done. Love looks out to the saints and works in the present. Hope looks ahead to what God has laid up for us, and that hope is secure because it is kept in heaven, not in our hands. Each of these was planted by one thing, the word of truth, the gospel.

Before Paul corrects a single error, he gives thanks for grace at work. That is a good place for us to begin as well. Grace saved us, grace grows us, grace equips us to serve, and grace makes us generous. Peace with God is already settled for every believer, and the peace of God is offered to guard our hearts today.

For reflection

1. If someone wrote a letter about your life this year, would faith, love, and hope be the first things they would see?
2. Which of the three, looking up, looking out, or looking ahead, needs the most attention in your life right now?
3. Who is an "Epaphras" in your life, someone who faithfully brought you the gospel or taught you the Word? Thank God for them by name.

Grace to you, and peace. The gospel is still bearing fruit, and it can bear fruit in you this week.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Writing from prison to a church he had never visited, Paul greets the Colossians with grace and peace and thanks God for the faith, love, and hope that the true gospel produced in them, laying the foundation for a letter that will exalt Christ as all-sufficient against a teaching that said He was not enough.

Outline

I. The Background of the Letter
- A. The Church Paul Had Never Seen
- B. The Occasion: An Early Form of Gnosticism
- C. Paul's Purpose in Writing

II. The Greeting (1:1–2)
- A. The Writer: Paul, an Apostle by the Will of God (1:1a)
- B. The Companion: Timothy Our Brother (1:1b)
- C. The Recipients: Saints and Faithful Brethren (1:2a)
- D. The Salutation: Grace and Peace (1:2b)

III. The Thanksgiving (1:3–8)
- A. The Statement of It (1:3)
- B. The Reasons for It: Faith, Love, and Hope (1:4–5a)
- C. The Source of It: The Gospel (1:5b–7a)
- D. The Messenger: Epaphras (1:7–8)

Introduction

The book of Acts closes with Paul in Rome, living for two years in his own rented quarters under guard (Acts 28:30). During that confinement he wrote four letters that we call the Prison Epistles: Ephesians, Colossians, Philemon, and Philippians. Ephesians and Colossians are sister letters, written about the same time and carried by the same messenger (Eph. 6:21–22; Col. 4:7–8). Both teach about the Church, the body of Christ, but from different directions. **Ephesians presents the body of which Christ is the Head. Colossians presents the Head of which the Church is the body.** Philemon is a personal letter about the runaway slave Onesimus, whom Paul led to the Lord and was now sending home. Philippians is the most autobiographical of the four and tells us much about Paul's confinement.

Three themes run through all of these letters, and we will meet them again and again in Colossians: Christ's **passion** for His Church and every believer in it, Christ's **plan** for His Church and the privilege and responsibility of every believer in it, and Christ's **provision** for His Church and every believer in it.

I. The Background of the Letter

A. The Church Paul Had Never Seen

Paul did not plant the church at Colossae, and he had never visited it (1:4, 7–8; 2:1). He did, however, spend three years in Ephesus, about a hundred miles to the west, and for two of those years he taught daily in the school of Tyrannus. Luke tells us what happened during that time:

> *"This took place for two years, so that all who lived in Asia heard the word of the Lord, both Jews and Greeks."*
>
> — Acts 19:10 (NASB95)

During that season of teaching, the gospel reached the Lycus Valley, and churches were born in Colossae, Laodicea, and Hierapolis (4:13). The man God used was Epaphras, a Colossian who had apparently heard Paul in Ephesus and carried the message home (1:7; 4:12). Some have suggested that all seven churches of Revelation 2–3 were founded in this same period. That is possible, but it cannot be proved.

B. The Occasion: An Early Form of Gnosticism

What prompted the letter was a particular false teaching that had arisen in Colossae. It appears to be an early form of what developed into full-blown Gnosticism in the second century. From the letter itself we can trace five of its features:

- **It was Jewish**, stressing the observance of Old Testament laws, foods, festivals, and Sabbaths (2:11, 16).
- **It was philosophical**, claiming a special, deeper knowledge (*gnōsis*) available only to the initiated (2:3–4, 8).
- **It involved the worship of angels** as mediators between man and God (2:18).
- **It was exclusive**, promising "perfection" to a select spiritual elite (1:28; 3:11).
- **It was Christological**, and it diminished the deity of Christ, which called forth some of the greatest statements of His deity anywhere in Scripture (1:15–19; 2:9).

The root of the system was a radical dualism: spirit is good and matter is evil. Think about where that leads. If matter is evil, a holy God can have nothing directly to do with the physical world, and there can certainly be no God-Man. So what do you do with Jesus? Either He was not truly God, or He was not truly man. That question produced two branches of error.

1. The Cerinthians: a man, but not God

Named for their founder, Cerinthus, this group taught that Jesus was only a man. "The Christ," a spirit, came upon Him at His baptism and left Him before the cross, so that the man Jesus died only as a man. Do you see what that does to the doctrine of Christ and to the doctrine of salvation? A mere man cannot die for the sins of the whole world. A mere man can only die for himself.

2. The Docetists: God, but not man

This group took its name from the Greek verb *dokeō*, "to seem." They taught that Jesus was only God and only *seemed* to have a body. You looked at Him and thought you saw a body, but you only thought you did. The problem here is just as serious: God, in His divine nature, cannot die. If Jesus had no real body, there was no real death, and no real payment for sin.

Against both errors Paul will insist that "in Him all the fullness of Deity dwells in bodily form" (2:9), and that He reconciled us "in His fleshly body through death" (1:22). Jesus Christ is fully God and fully man, one Person forever.

C. Paul's Purpose in Writing

- To show the **deity and supremacy of Christ** in the face of the Colossian heresy (1:18; 2:9).
- To lead believers into **spiritual maturity** (1:28; 2:6–7).
- To **inform them of his circumstances** and enlist their prayers on his behalf (4:2–9).

II. The Greeting (1:1–2)

A. The Writer: Paul, an Apostle by the Will of God (1:1a)

Paul calls himself "an apostle of Jesus Christ" in every one of his letters except Philippians, 1 and 2 Thessalonians, and Philemon. He was not one of the Twelve, and he had not been with Jesus from the beginning of His ministry (Acts 1:21–22). But he had seen the risen Lord (1 Cor. 9:1; 15:8–9), and he displayed the signs that authenticated an apostle (2 Cor. 12:12). His authority did not come from a committee, from a vote, or from his own ambition. It came "by the will of God." That matters in a letter written to correct error: Paul is not offering one opinion among many.

B. The Companion: Timothy Our Brother (1:1b)

Timothy had a Gentile father and a godly Jewish mother and grandmother (Acts 16:1; 2 Tim. 1:5), from whom he learned the Scriptures from childhood (2 Tim. 3:15). Paul picked him up at Lystra on the second missionary journey, where the brothers spoke well of him (Acts 16:2). Paul invested years in discipling Timothy and wrote two of his last letters to him. Here Timothy is simply "our brother," a reminder that the greatest of the apostles did not minister alone.

C. The Recipients: Saints and Faithful Brethren (1:2a)

"Saints" (*hagioi*) means "holy ones," those set apart for God. The word describes, first, the believer's **standing**. Every believer is a saint the moment he believes, because he is "in Christ," chosen and set apart for God. Paul calls even the troubled Corinthian church "saints" (1 Cor. 1:2). The word also points to the believer's **state**, the call to live out that holiness. The Colossians were doing so; otherwise Paul would hardly have added that they were "faithful brethren." They were holding to the teaching Epaphras had given them, and the false teachers had not yet broken their ranks (2:5).

D. The Salutation: Grace and Peace (1:2b)

Paul's familiar greeting is not a formality. Both words are packed with truth.

1. Grace in four dimensions

Everything God does for us is by grace, His undeserved favor. In the New Testament we can trace at least four ways grace touches the believer:

- **Saving grace.** God freely forgives our sins and gives eternal life to all who believe in His Son (Eph. 2:8–9).
- **Sanctifying grace.** God graciously works to conform us to the image of His Son.
- **Serving grace.** We cannot serve God acceptably apart from His grace (Heb. 12:28).
- **Sharing grace.** Paul calls the generous giving of the Macedonians a "grace" (2 Cor. 8:1–7).

> *“Therefore, since we receive a kingdom which cannot be shaken, let us show gratitude, by which we may offer to God an acceptable service with reverence and awe;”*
>
> — Hebrews 12:28 (NASB95)

In a greeting to people who are already saved, the emphasis falls on the grace that keeps working in them: the grace to grow, to serve, and to give.

2. Peace in three dimensions

The Greek word is *eirēnē*, and behind it stands the rich Hebrew word *shalom*, wholeness and well-being. Scripture speaks of peace in three ways:

Peace with God. This is the peace of a settled relationship, and it belongs to every believer from the moment of faith:

> *“Therefore, having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ,”*
>
> — Romans 5:1 (NASB95)

If you have been justified by faith, you have peace with God, and nothing can take that peace away. That is not a feeling; it is a fact.

The God of peace. Paul could point to his own life as an example and promise that the God of peace would be with those who followed it (Phil. 4:9). A godly walk enjoys the company of the God of peace.

The peace of God. This is the peace God gives in the middle of hard circumstances:

> *“Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all comprehension, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.”*
>
> — Philippians 4:6–7 (NASB95)

How do we keep from being anxious? Talk to God about it; that is prayer. Ask Him for specific things; that is supplication. Remember what He has already given; that is

thanksgiving. The problem may still be there, but God places His peace between us and the problem, and that peace stands guard like a garrison over our hearts and minds.

A brief textual note: the NASB95 ends verse 2 with "from God our Father," while the NKJV adds "and the Lord Jesus Christ," following other manuscripts. Nothing changes either way. Paul joins the Father and the Son as the source of grace and peace in every other letter, and all grace and peace come to us through the cross of Christ.

III. The Thanksgiving (1:3–8)

A. The Statement of It (1:3)

Paul gives thanks "to God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, praying always for you." Paul had never met these people, yet he prayed for them constantly. Thanksgiving is the first note he strikes, and it is one of the threads of the whole letter (1:3, 12; 2:7; 3:15–17; 4:2).

B. The Reasons for It: Faith, Love, and Hope (1:4–5a)

Paul names the three graces he names so often (1 Cor. 13:13; 1 Thess. 1:3), and here each one faces a different direction in time.

1. Faith looks up and rests on the past (1:4a)

"Your faith in Christ Jesus." Faith looks upward to God, and it rests on the finished work of Christ at the cross. Its object is not a system, a ritual, or a feeling, but a Person.

2. Love looks out and works in the present (1:4b)

"The love which you have for all the saints." Love looks outward to others, and it works now. Notice the word "all." The false teaching in Colossae was exclusive, prizing an inner circle. Genuine Christian love embraces all the saints.

3. Hope looks ahead to the future (1:5a)

"Because of the hope laid up for you in heaven." Biblical hope is not wishful thinking but confident expectation. The verb (*apokeimai*) pictures something stored away and reserved. Our hope is safe because it is kept in heaven, where no thief, false teacher, or failure of ours can reach it. Notice, too, the order of the logic: their love for the saints flowed *because of* the hope laid up for them. Believers who are secure in what God has reserved for them are set free to love.

C. The Source of It: The Gospel (1:5b–7a)

Where did this faith, love, and hope come from? From "the word of truth, the gospel." Paul describes that gospel in four ways.

- **Its universality:** it "has come to you, just as in all the world also." The gospel is not a local or private message for an elite.
- **Its productivity:** it "is constantly bearing fruit and increasing." The true gospel produces life wherever it goes.
- **Its individuality:** "even as it has been doing in you also since the day you heard of it." The worldwide message became personal in Colossae.

- **Its identity:** they "understood the grace of God in truth." The gospel is the message of God's grace. Add anything to grace, and it is no longer the gospel.

This description is a quiet shot across the bow of the false teachers. The Colossians did not need a newer, deeper, more exclusive message. The gospel they first heard was true, worldwide, and fruitful.

D. The Messenger: Epaphras (1:7–8)

God used a man to bring this message to Colossae, and Paul honors him in four ways:

- **A student of Paul.** "Just as you learned it from Epaphras." He was apparently converted or trained during Paul's years in Ephesus, then carried the message home.
- **A beloved fellow bond-servant** (*syndoulos*). Paul does not rank himself above him. They are slaves of the same Master.
- **A faithful servant (*diakonos*) of Christ.** The NASB95 reads "on our behalf," that is, Epaphras went to Colossae in Paul's place, since Paul could not go. The NKJV reads "on your behalf," following other manuscripts. Either way, Epaphras was a faithful servant, and either way the Colossians had heard the same gospel Paul preached.
- **A messenger from them.** "He also informed us of your love in the Spirit." Their love was not merely human affection. It was produced by the Holy Spirit, which is why the NASB capitalizes "Spirit."

Conclusion

Before Paul answers a single error, he thanks God for grace at work. The Colossians had faith that looked up, love that reached out, and hope that looked ahead, and all three grew from the simple gospel of the grace of God. Over the next eleven studies, Paul will show that this gospel and this Christ are enough. Nothing needs to be added, because Christ is all, and in all (3:11).

The question to carry home is simple: Has the gospel come to you, and is it bearing fruit in you? If you have believed in Jesus Christ, you have peace with God, a hope laid up in heaven, and a Savior who is sufficient for everything that lies ahead in this letter and in your life.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.1	**ἀπόστολος** *apostle*	**G652** *apostolos* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** one sent forth with orders; a delegate, messenger. **VINE:** used of the Twelve and of Paul, who were commissioned directly by the risen Christ. **Significance:** Paul writes with delegated authority "by the will of God," which is why his correction of the Colossian error carries weight.
v.2	**ἅγιος** *saints*	**G40** *hagios* Dat. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** set apart for God, consecrated; as a noun, "holy ones." **LXX:** used of Israel as a people set apart to the Lord (Exod. 19:6). **Significance:** Every believer is a saint by position in Christ; the letter calls saints to live out what they already are.
v.2	**πιστός** *faithful*	**G4103** *pistos* Dat. Masc. Pl.	**STR:** trustworthy, faithful; also believing. **VINE:** can mean "believing" or "reliable"; context decides. **Significance:** Paired with "brethren," it commends the Colossians as believers who were holding steady in the truth.
v.2	**χάρις** *grace*	**G5485** *charis* Nom. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** goodwill, kindness, favor freely given; the merciful kindness by which God exerts His holy influence on souls. **Significance:** Grace saves, sanctifies, equips for service, and makes generous; the false teachers wanted to add to what grace had freely given.
v.2	**εἰρήνη** *peace*	**G1515** *eirēnē* Nom. Fem. Sg.	**STR:** peace, quietness, rest; set at one again. **LXX:** regularly translates Hebrew *shalom*, wholeness and well-being. **Significance:** Peace with God is settled at justification (Rom. 5:1); the peace of God guards the believer's heart in trouble (Phil. 4:7).
v.3	**εὐχαριστέω** *we give thanks*	**G2168** *eucharisteō* Pres. Act. Ind. 1st Pl.	**STR:** to be grateful, to express gratitude. **ATR:** the present tense marks a continuing habit of thanksgiving. **Significance:** Thanksgiving is Paul's first response and a recurring command of the letter (2:7; 3:15–17; 4:2).
v.4	**πίστις** *faith*	**G4102** *pistis* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** conviction of the truth; trust in Christ. **VINE:** its object here is "Christ Jesus" (*en Christō Iēsou*).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
			Significance: Faith looks up and rests on Christ's finished work; its value lies in its object.
v.4	**ἀγάπη** *love*	**G26** *agapē* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** love that seeks the good of its object; expressed in action, not merely feeling. **Significance:** Love looks outward to "all the saints," the opposite of the exclusive spirit of the false teaching.
v.5	**ἐλπίς** *hope*	**G1680** *elpis* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** joyful and confident expectation of eternal salvation. **Significance:** Biblical hope is certainty about the future, not wishful thinking; it is the ground of their love (v.5, "because of").
v.5	**ἀπόκειμαι** *laid up*	**G606** *apokeimai* Pres. Mid./Pass. Ptc. Acc. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** to be laid away, reserved. **MRV:** used of goods stored away for safekeeping. **Significance:** The believer's hope is kept in heaven, beyond the reach of false teachers or circumstances.
v.6	**καρποφορέω** *bearing fruit*	**G2592** *karpophoreō* Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Neut. Sg.	**ATR:** the middle voice suggests the gospel bears fruit of itself, by its inherent life. **Significance:** The true gospel is productive everywhere it goes; it needs no supplement to make it work.
v.7	**σύνδουλος** *fellow bond-servant*	**G4889** *syndoulos* Gen. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** a co-slave, one who serves the same master. **Significance:** Paul places Epaphras beside himself as a slave of the same Lord, not beneath him.
v.7	**διάκονος** *servant, minister*	**G1249** *diakonos* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**VINE:** a servant, attendant; used of ministry generally, not here of the church office. **Significance:** Epaphras was a faithful servant of Christ who carried the gospel to Colossae when Paul could not go.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
How do Ephesians and Colossians differ in emphasis?	Ephesians presents the body of which Christ is the Head; Colossians presents the Head of which the Church is the body.
What was the root belief of the Colossian heresy?	Radical dualism: spirit is good and matter is evil, so God could not become a real man.
What did the Cerinthians and Docetists	Cerinthians: that Jesus was God (a mere man died). Docetists:

Review prompt	From the commentary
each deny?	that Jesus was truly man (He only seemed to have a body).
Name the four dimensions of grace.	Saving, sanctifying, serving (Heb. 12:28), and sharing (2 Cor. 8:1–7).
Name the three dimensions of peace.	Peace with God (Rom. 5:1), the God of peace (Phil. 4:9), and the peace of God (Phil. 4:6–7).
How do faith, love, and hope face different directions?	Faith looks up and rests on the past; love looks out and works in the present; hope looks ahead to the future.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Paul had never visited Colossae (2:1). How did the gospel reach the city, and what does that teach us about how God spreads His Word?

> **Leader's answer:** During Paul's two years of teaching in the school of Tyrannus, "all who lived in Asia heard the word of the Lord" (Acts 19:10). Epaphras apparently heard Paul and carried the message home (1:7). God multiplies His Word through faithful learners who become teachers; Paul did not have to go everywhere himself.

2. Why would the Colossian heresy's view of matter lead to a wrong view of Jesus, and why does that matter for salvation?

> **Leader's answer:** If matter is evil, God cannot truly become man. That forces a choice: Jesus was not truly God (Cerinthians) or not truly man (Docetists). Either way there is no Savior: a mere man cannot die for the world, and God in His divine nature cannot die. Only the God-Man who died "in His fleshly body" (1:22) can reconcile us.

3. What is the difference between the believer's standing as a "saint" and his state?

> **Leader's answer:** Standing is positional: every believer is set apart to God "in Christ" from the moment of faith, even the troubled Corinthians (1 Cor. 1:2). State is practical: living out that holiness. The Colossians were also "faithful brethren," holding to the truth they had been taught.

4. According to verse 5, why did the Colossians love all the saints? What does that suggest about the link between assurance and love?

> **Leader's answer:** They loved "because of the hope laid up for you in heaven." A secure, reserved hope frees believers from self-concern and fear, so they can pour themselves out for others. Assurance is not a barrier to love; it fuels it.

5. List the four things Paul says about the gospel in verses 5–6. How do they answer the false teachers?

> **Leader's answer:** Its universality (in all the world), its productivity (bearing fruit and increasing), its individuality (in you also), and its identity (the grace of God in truth). The false teachers offered an exclusive, "deeper" add-on; Paul says the gospel they first heard is already true, worldwide, fruitful, and all of grace.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
1:1	The writer	Paul writes as an apostle by the will of God, with Timothy his brother.
1:2	The greeting	Saints and faithful brethren receive grace and peace from God.
1:3–5a	The thanksgiving	Paul thanks God for their faith in Christ, love for all the saints, and hope laid up in heaven.
1:5b–6	The gospel	The word of truth is worldwide, fruitful, personal, and all of grace.
1:7–8	The messenger	Epaphras, a faithful servant, taught them and reported their Spirit-given love.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Know What You Believe About Jesus

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:9; 1:22

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.B (Cerinthians and Docetists)

The errors in Colossae did not deny Jesus outright; they redefined Him. The same is true today. Some say Jesus was a good teacher but not God; others treat Him as a spiritual idea with no real body or real death. Our salvation depends on the Jesus of Scripture: fully God, so His death could pay for the world, and fully man, so He could die in our place.

Reflection: Could you explain to a friend, in two or three sentences, why Jesus had to be both God and man?

Practical step: Write out Colossians 2:9 and 1:22 on a card and read them aloud each morning this week.

2. Rest in Peace with God, Then Pray for the Peace of God

Scripture anchor: Romans 5:1; Philippians 4:6–7

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.D.2, and ② Devotional

Peace with God is settled for every believer from the moment of faith, and nothing can take it away. The peace of God is something we draw on day by day when anxiety knocks. The first is a fact to believe; the second is a gift to receive through prayer, supplication, and thanksgiving.

Reflection: What worry are you carrying right now that you have not brought to God in specific prayer with thanksgiving?

Practical step: Name one anxiety, pray specifically about it, and list three things you are thankful for in that same situation.

3. Let Your Hope Fuel Your Love

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:4–5

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.B, and ④ Study Question 4; cf. Hodges, Grace in Eclipse (FGR)

The Colossians loved all the saints because of the hope laid up for them in heaven. A believer who is sure of his eternal future is free to give himself to others now, not to earn heaven but because heaven is already secure. Free Grace teachers have long stressed this point: the gift of eternal life is settled, so the believer's energy can go into love, service, and faithfulness that the Lord will one day reward.

Reflection: Is there a believer outside your usual circle whom you could love in a practical way this week?

Practical step: Choose one person in your church whom you seldom speak with and do one concrete act of kindness for them.

4. Thank God for Your Epaphras

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:7–8

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.D, and ② Devotional

Most of us came to faith or grew in faith because someone faithfully taught us the Word. Paul honored Epaphras publicly as a beloved fellow servant. Gratitude for the people God has used in our lives is part of the thanksgiving that marks this whole letter.

Reflection: Who brought you the gospel, or who taught you the Scriptures in a way that changed your life?

Practical step: Send a short note or message of thanks to that person this week, or thank God for them by name if they are with the Lord.

End of Study · Colossians 1:1–8